to ally with Fuladi instead.

For Akbar – and for his chronicler – the chaos was all to the good. As he had written of Akbar bringing justice to Baz Bahadur's Malwa, so Abul Fazl now muses on how the padishah's 'first thought' when conquering countries was 'to inquire into and sympathise with the condition of the oppressed' – a noble ambition that God, it seems, was more than willing to encourage, for 'He makes a country empty of just rulers', thus giving Akbar the perfect excuse to swoop in.[13]

Who knows, perhaps God *was* loading the dice in Akbar's favour. In the late summer of 1572, as Gujarat careened in turmoil and Akbar marched west, news arrived that Sultan Sulaiman Karrani of Bengal had died. Not one but two fronts had opened to Akbar, not one but two busy coasts might now be his, and the sun's rays might rise and fall, uninterrupted, across his domain.

At some point in the voluminous *Akbarnama*, Abul Fazl lists the eight principles of world rule. The first is good luck; and Akbar knew not to waste such providential opportunities. He sent word to Munim Khan, stationed in Jaunpur since the Uzbeks' defeat, to begin an onslaught upon Bengal; himself, the padishah continued west.

His very approach, it seems, scattered Gujarat's warring nobility. Fuladi, besieging Itimad Khan in Ahmedabad with help from the Mirzas, fled at news of Akbar's approach, abandoning both the siege and Nannu, claimant to the Muzaffarid throne, who was found hiding in a wheat field. Itimad Khan, who had already written to Akbar asking for help against his besiegers, came to prostrate himself before his new lord.[14] One by one, the nobility of Gujarat followed, and Akbar, 'mounted in his glory on an elephant', rode upon Ahmedabad, chatting amiably with his new courtiers.[15]

It would have been hard for any man not to start believing in his own destiny.

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Among the men who sent their submissions to Akbar during his initial, rather leisurely invasion of Gujarat, was Ibrahim Husain, the best known and most ambitious – and reviled – of the Mirzas, who now enter to play